exercise health professionals and scientists.[53] There have, of course, been similar calamities over history. The H1N1 influenza pandemic of 1918-19 is now estimated to have killed at least fifty million people. In the bubonic plague of the fourteenth century (the Black Death), between seventy-five and 200 million people are believed to have died between 1346 and 1353. Some forty million people have perished from HIV/Aids since the 1980s. Preventable diseases such as tuberculosis and malaria continue to devastate populations in the developing world (despite successful vaccines and treatments in the developed world). The World Health Organisation estimated that in 2008 tobacco killed nearly five and a half million people a year. It warned that as many as a billion people could die this century from tobacco-related causes without urgent international action.

Some catastrophes were the direct consequence of political action. The great famines of the twentieth century were driven by Marxist-Leninist and Maoist ideologies: in Ukraine in the 1930s an estimated five million people starved to death as a result of Stalin's attempts to 'collectivise' Soviet agriculture. In China, the human cost of Mao Zedong's 'Great Leap Forward' is measured in tens of millions, with estimates as high as fifty-five million.

War is a recurring part of human history. According to an analysis by Chris Hedges in 2003, over the past 3,400 years, humankind has been free of war (defined as an active conflict that has killed over a thousand people) for just 268 of them.[54] That tally has not increased since 2003. The number killed throughout recorded history has been estimated as between 150 million to one billion. At least 108 million people died in the wars of the twentieth century. The Second World War killed between forty and fifty million. In Europe, six to seven million people were murdered in Nazi concentration and extermination camps, some six million of them Jewish. The Germans were also responsible for the deaths of over two million Soviet prisoners of war. The term genocide entered the twentieth-century political lexicon to describe attempts to destroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnic, racial, or religious group. In Rwanda, in 1994, some 800,000–1,000,000 Tutsis were massacred by the Hutu majority (of whom an estimated 100,000 were also killed). The term genocide was also applied